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Principles and Practices
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A Letter to my Future Self

Dear Future James,

I hope this letter finds me well, but as I am writing with your worst day in mind, I'll assume that might not be the case. I want you to remember who you are and what you've accomplished to this point. I want you to know how much I believe in you in this moment and the beautiful, powerful, transformational teaching career I see ahead of you. I want you to take a second to appreciate all of the love and support you can count on and I want to remind you of the bigger picture; the great vast world in which you are just a speck of dust and a blip in time and the power that gives you to decide who you are.

You spent some time figuring out that this is what you are meant to be doing; all the more reason to have the confidence that you can keep moving forward. There isn't a challenge that can be thrown at you that you can't overcome and learn from. You've always taken the setbacks in stride and found success through perseverance. You were never just a good student, you were the best; you didn't just work at camp, you excelled as a leader; you juggled classes with two executive positions on the ACSS, starting a brand new club, tutoring, and TAing, never missed a beat and had a perfect GPA in your senior year. When the job market took a turn for software developers, you still found work. When part-time wasn't enough to cover expenses, you picked up shifts at Starbucks and learned faster and worked harder than any of the other baristas. When you had to take a step back and work in a door factory while you figured things out, you were up rain or shine at 4:30am, the only guy since Willis who could keep up on the brickmould welder, and got the best performance review your supervisor had seen in years. Whatever it is, you can handle it.

Whether or not you can see it now, you're doing good, meaningful, worthwhile work. Remember that love is the whole point and that you're beyond blessed to be able to show it to the people around you right now. You believe (and I know you still do) that a better tomorrow is on the horizon because of the work we do today to make it so. Even when it feels like what you're doing can't mean anything, especially when it feels like what you're

doing can't mean anything, remember that to each of the students you interacted with today, it could mean everything.

I don't know what the future holds, but I can say without a doubt that you have so many people on your side right now – more than you think if you take a second to stop and appreciate them. Reach out; odds are they'll at the very least commiserate with you about whatever feels like the end of the world right now. On that note, remember that most everyone is kinder than you give them credit for. The world is full of good, flawed people trying their very best with what they've been given. Have patience as you have been shown patience and love as you have been shown love.

Remember that the meaning of life is yours to decide, that the world around you is what you make of it. Go for a walk outside and listen. Remember that every tree and blade of grass is unique and full of life and realize that there is so much more to everything than you can possibly imagine. Tomorrow is a new day and on and on past everything you've ever known and everything that ever will be – you are here now and you are doing alright.

Wherever you are, whatever you're doing, whether everything went according to the plan or like nothing I could even conceive of: I'm proud of you.

Yours truly,
Past James